BOOKS

EXTRAORDINARY MOVIES ABOUT ORDINARY LIVES

This book by Anirudha Bhattacharjee celebrates the feelgood cinema of Basu Chatterji



BASU CHATTERJI AND MIDDLE-OF-THE-ROAD CINEMA
By Anirudha Bhattacharjee
PENGUIN VINTAGE
₹699; 320 pages

As soon as I saw *Basu Chatterji* on a store shelf, I wanted to read it. Though many current readers may not readily know of him—their touchstones of middle-of-the-road cinema would be gems such as *Dum Laga ke Haisha* (2015) or *Badhaai Ho* (2018)—he was, as Pearl Padamsee put it, the master of the low-budget film. His were the antithesis of the other memorable strain of the '70s films—the angry-young-man movies. Chatterji's films were anything but angry—they were middle-class character studies that sought to, as biographer Anirudha Bhattacharjee says in his book, find the lighter interludes of an ordinary life filled with burdens and obligations. Or, he depicted the independent-minded young woman.

Chatterji was loved by producers because he kept to a low budget and a quick three-week shoot. He was loved by actors because, as testified by the over 60 film personalities Bhattacharjee interviewed, the shoot was "like a picnic" (and film raconteurs like Utpal Dutt or Dadamoni Ashok Kumar also enjoyed the post-shoot whisky-fuelled "adda"). He was loved by cinema-goers because in the chaos that was urban India, in his films the oasis was the family.

This book is more a filmography, fleshed out by reminiscences, than a biography or hagiography. Starting with his first, *Sara Akash* (1969), based on a real-life story by Rajendra Yadav of a long-unconsummated marriage; to the story of a woman in love with two men (shocking!) *Rajnigandha* (1974); to chawl-life *Piya ka Ghar* from 1972 (whose tune 'Yeh jeevan hai' has been a reverb in my head for half a century); to *Chitchor* (1976) to *Khatta Meetha* (1978) to *Swami* (1977)... oh, the list goes on.

Bhattacharjee points out that the films were strongest when adapted from Indian literature; Chatterji had to be restrained from trying to adapt Czech or Turkish or even American films. And even in his numerous flops, the elements that endure are the songs, the kind everyone back then would hum on a bus or a train. Strangely, Chatterji did not like lip-synched songs, arguing they were unnatural.

Though Bhattacharjee is sometimes pedantic with his repeated focus on Chatterji's continuity sloppiness, this is an engaging read and like Chatterji's films, leaves you with a warm feeling throughout. For further enjoyment, listen to the songs between sittings! ■

Aditya Sinha

BOOKS

THE RANI VANISHES

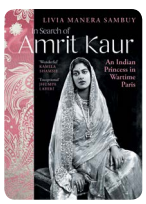
ITALIAN JOURNALIST **LIVIA MANERA SAMBUY** PIECES TOGETHER THE SCINTILLATING TALE OF AMRIT KAUR, THE KAPURTHALA PRINCESS WHO WAS IMPRISONED BY THE GESTAPO

On a visit to Mumbai in 2007, the author sees a photograph that will change her life. It's a monochrome portrait made in 1924, of Rani Amrit Kaur of Mandi, shimmering in her tissue sari and jewels.

The caption claims that the sad-eyed princess of Kapurthala was arrested by the Gestapo in wartime France "on the accusation of having sold her jewellery to help Jews escape the country". Sent to an internment camp, she "survived less than a year of Nazi imprisonment".

This tiny scrap of history launches Sambuy, Italian author and journalist, on a 15-year quest to dig up the truth. Red herrings and side stories keep the facts stubbornly out of reach. Eighteen months after seeing the photograph, she travels to Pune to meet the Rani's daughter, Nirvana Devi of Bilkha, or Bubbles. But the diminutive silver-haired lady exclaims, "I know nothing about my mother!" The Rani left Mandi for Europe in 1933, abandoning her two children and husband, never to return. Bubbles was not yet four. The only thing she knows for sure is that her mother died in 1948 in the UK, not in 1941 in France.

What happened in the chasm of time between the flight from India and the death in England? Archival correspondence between the British Foreign Office and the Rani's father, Maharaja Jagatjit Singh of Kapurthala, reveals that he tried to rescue her from the Nazis, but failed, at least initially. Troubling questions plague the author: why would an Indian princess risk her life to help Jews escape to safety? Why did she never write to her children? How did some of her fabulous jewels find their way to American auction houses?



THE SEARCH FOR AMRIT KAUR An Indian Princess in Wartime Paris
by Livia Manera Sambuy
English translation by Todd Portnowitz
CHATTO & WINDUS
₹799; 330 pages

The saga that unfolds has the momentum of detective fiction. Astounding coincidences abound. Two jewellers flying first class from India gossip about an unforgettable double-stranded pearl necklace: the very one the Rani wore in the 1924 photograph. Just as all Sambuy's leads dry up, a dinner engagement in Paris yields a telephone number in the US. A crocodile-leather briefcase that may contain letters and photographs of the Rani's secret history, miraculously surfaces in San Diego.

Sambuy writes with warm empathy for India's once-royals. They grace the pages of her book with dignity and good humour even as the ugly chaos of our world swallows up the last traces of their vanished glory. ■

Manjula Padmanabhan